

PEACE AND JUSTICE: VEDANTIC PERSPECTIVE

- DR. (PROF.) JATA SHANKAR
(ALLAHABAD, INDIA)

Abstract

In this Article an attempt has been made to understand the concepts of Peace and Justice in traditional Indian thought. The author has reasons to believe that *Vedānta* (*Upanishads*) has been a guiding principle of Indian society for quite a long period and through the teachings of *Bhagavad Gitā* it continues even today. *Vedānta* as a system of Indian Philosophy is founded on three pillars i.e. *Upanishads*, *Bramhasutra*, and *Bhagavad Gita* which is known as three points of departure (*Prasthān Trayi*). The second point which attracts author's mind is that all-pervasive concept of Dharma has been used as a synonym for Justice and ultimately it leads to the Peace in our individual and social lives. *Dharma* is understood under different classifications. One such classification is - Universal (*Sādhāran*) *Dharma*, that represents the code of conduct for entire human race; Personal (*Vishishta*) *Dharma*, which varies from person to person and community to community; and Emergent (*Apad*) *Dharma*, which is valid only during emergent situations. In all these forms, *Dharma* stands as a standard to decide what to do and what not to do.

Thirdly, the goal of human life has been described as *Purushārtha* and their realisation is believed to be the source of both Peace and Justice. It has also been observed that the balance of the first three *Purushārtha* i.e. *Dharma*, *Artha* and *Kāma* is necessary for a peaceful life and a just society (*Dharmārth Kāmāh Samamev Sevyāh* – Kautilya). This equilibrium of the three ultimately leads to the fourth *Purushārtha* i.e. *Moksha*, which is *summum bonum* of human life. *Dharma*

is the dynamic force which makes it possible that *Artha* and *Kāma* meaningfully help us in the realisation of *Moksha*. The fourth point of this Article tries to look into vedic prayer for cosmic peace (“*Dyauh Shanti Antariksham Shantih...*” Yajurveda, Atharveda – Rudrashtadhyayi) and the method to achieve it as described in *Bhagavad Gita* (‘*Nirmamo Nirhankarah sa Shantimadhigachchhati*).

The Article concludes with the understanding that Peace and Justice are inter-dependent and jointly they are the means for the highest goal of life known with different names like *Moksha*, *Nirvāna*, Salvation, *Apvarga* etc.

Keywords: *Dharma, Peace and Justice, Purushartha, Vedanta, Bhagavad Gita, Yajurveda, Atharvaveda, Kautilya.*